

CHAPTER FIFTEEN

Forgiveness ≠ Trust

In late January, Amara had to think about Brielle.

Brielle had said something about Amara, in the second week of January, that had gotten back to Amara through three people. The thing Brielle had said had been small but specific. Brielle had said, to Cassidy and one other girl, *Amara is so much weirder this year. Like, she used to be cool, and now she has gone back to that whole I am intense and serious thing she did in sixth grade for a minute. I cannot really hang out with her like this.*

The thing had reached Amara on a Thursday afternoon, from Cassidy directly, who had — and this was important — Cassidy had not been entirely sure she should be telling Amara, but Cassidy had decided that she would rather Amara know than not know. Cassidy had said, *Amara, I want to tell you a thing Brielle said. You can be mad at me for telling you. I just — I thought you should know.* Cassidy had told her.

Amara had thanked Cassidy.

Amara had walked home.

Amara had cried in her bedroom for forty-five minutes.

Then Amara had done something she had not, in a long time, done — she had called her grandmother.

Her grandmother had picked up.

Amara had told her grandmother the whole story.

Amara's grandmother had listened.

When Amara was done, her grandmother had said, *baby*. I want to tell you several things. Are you ready.

Amara had said, yes.

Her grandmother had said:

One. Brielle was wrong to say that. The saying was unkind. Cassidy was right to tell you. The information helps you understand what kind of friend Brielle has been and is.

Two. Baby, you are not weirder this year. You are, in fact, more yourself this year. The cohort-Amara has been getting bigger. The adjacent-Amara has been getting smaller. That is exactly what we have been talking about for years. The fact that Brielle is saying Amara is weirder is, in some real way, Brielle telling on herself. Brielle preferred adjacent-Amara because adjacent-Amara was an easier friend to have. Real-Amara is, to Brielle, more inconvenient. That is the actual translation of what she said.

Three. You are going to have to decide what to do about the friendship. You do not have to decide today. You do not have to decide this week. But you are going to need to think about what kind of friendship Brielle has been offering you, and whether you want to keep accepting it, and what that means.

Four. Whatever you decide, you are going to have to do a thing in your head that we are going to call – I do not know what the cohort calls it, but I am going to call it – putting Brielle down. You are carrying Brielle's words right now. You are going to keep carrying them, in some form, until you choose to put them down. The putting-down is for you, not for Brielle. The putting-down does not require Brielle to apologize. The putting-down does not require you to be friends with Brielle. The putting-down is the work you do in your own head, so that Brielle's words stop renting space in there.

Amara had said, *Grandma*. The cohort calls that something. I think the cohort calls it — I think Ms. Calloway has been teaching us about it for years. Forgiveness, but the kind that does not include trust.

Her grandmother had said, *baby*. Yes. That is exactly what I mean. The forgiving is internal. The trust is between two people. The two are not the same. You can forgive Brielle without trusting Brielle. You can forgive Brielle without ever being close to Brielle again. The forgiveness is yours to give yourself. The trust is a separate, slower question.

Amara had been very quiet for a minute.

Then Amara had said, *Grandma*. How do I — how do I do the putting-down.

Her grandmother had said, *baby*. You start by saying, in your head, what is true. Brielle said what she said. You did not deserve it. The version of you Brielle preferred is not the version of you that is real. Brielle is going to have to find a different friend, because you are not going to be adjacent-Amara anymore, ever again. The Brielle that said what she said is not the kind of friend you want. You forgive her. You do not, however, trust her. You move on.

That is the script, *baby*. You may have to say it many times. You will say it tomorrow morning. You will say it tomorrow at lunch when you see Brielle. You will say it next week, when Brielle and Cassidy walk past your locker. You will say it for as long as it takes for the saying to feel automatic.

That is the practice.

Amara had said, *Grandma*. Thank you.

Her grandmother had said, *Baby*. I am proud of you. Sunday dinner this week, yes?

Amara had said, yes.

She had hung up.

She had sat in her room for a long time.

She had written, in her journal:

Brielle said what she said. I did not deserve it. The version of me Brielle preferred is not the real one. The real one is not weird, the real one is just real. Brielle is going to have to find a different friend. I forgive her. I do not trust her. I am moving on.

She had read it twice. She had closed the journal. She had gone downstairs to dinner.



This is what forgiveness looks like, in seventh grade, when the other person has not apologized and probably will not.

It does not look like a reconciliation.

It does not look like Amara going up to Brielle on Friday and saying *hey, I forgive you for what you said*. That would be — and Amara's grandmother knew this even though Amara had not yet — that would be giving Brielle a piece of information Brielle could weaponize. Brielle did not know that Amara had heard about the comment. Going up to Brielle and announcing forgiveness would have been handing Brielle the script.

Forgiveness, here, is interior.

Forgiveness, here, is Amara doing the work in her own head, in her own journal, in conversations with her grandmother, so that Brielle's words stop running her interior life. The work is evicting Brielle from Amara's head. Brielle had been, since Thursday, living rent-free in Amara's head. Amara was going to make her leave.

The making-her-leave is forgiveness.

The making-her-leave does not require Brielle to do anything. Brielle does not have to apologize. Brielle does not have to know. Brielle could keep saying things about Amara to Cassidy for the rest of seventh grade and still Amara could, in

her own head, have put Brielle down. The forgiveness is not for Brielle. The forgiveness is for Amara.

This is the most important sentence in the chapter, and we are going to say it three different ways:

Forgiveness is what you do when you stop letting somebody else's behavior continue to shape your inner life.

Forgiveness is the eviction notice you sign for somebody who has been living in your head without paying rent.

Forgiveness is the daily decision to stop carrying what they did, even though they have not asked you to put it down.

Forgiveness, when it works, is one of the most freeing experiences a human being can have. It is also, often, invisible to the person who did the harm. They do not see it. They do not benefit from it. They do not know it happened. The benefit is entirely yours.

The architecture of grace is, in some real way, an architecture of taking back your own house.

That is what Amara did, on a Thursday in January, with her grandmother on the phone.

The cohort, in the coming weeks, would do their own versions. Marcus would do a small version about a kid who had teased him in fifth grade who had moved away. Priya would do one about a teacher in sixth grade who had said something that had stuck. Theo would do one about — and this would be the one the cohort did not know about for years — Theo would do one about an uncle who had hurt his sister Lena when Theo was small, in ways Theo had not, until seventh grade, fully understood. Theo would not do that one alone — Theo would do that one with Ms. Calloway and Ms. Wong and his mother all present, and it would take months. But Theo would, in seventh grade, do the work.

Each of them, in their own way, would be evicting somebody.

The cohort, this winter, is doing the eviction work.



A note about trust.

Forgiveness is not the same as trust.

We are going to say this loudly because the confusion between them has hurt people, including kids your age, including kids in this very curriculum's previous pilots.

If somebody hurt you, you can forgive them — interiorly, in your own head — and also decide that you do not want them in your life anymore. That is allowed. That is, sometimes, the right call.

If somebody hurt you and apologized and did the repair shape — *I see the impact, I am not defending the intention, I am sorry* — and you forgave them, you might let them back into the closer parts of your life. That is the trust question. The trust question is a separate, slower, more careful question.

Trust is rebuilt over time, in small increments, by the person who did the harm doing the thing differently. Trust is not a thing you grant by deciding to. Trust is something you observe building, in the data of how the person behaves in the months after the apology. The person who keeps doing the harm has not earned trust back, no matter how good their apology was. The person who, over six months, behaves consistently and kindly is earning it back, whether or not you have told them so. Trust is data, over time.

Forgiveness is a decision, made interiorly, that does not require their participation.

Most kids — and most adults, frankly — confuse these. They think that forgiving somebody means they have to trust them

again. They think that not trusting somebody means they have not forgiven them. Both confusions cause real harm. The first one keeps people in friendships and relationships that are hurting them, because they think forgiveness requires re-entry. The second one keeps people in resentment they could put down, because they think that putting it down would mean granting access they have not granted.

Forgiveness and trust are two separate ledgers.

You can do the forgiveness work today and not do the trust work for years, or ever. That is allowed.

Amara, in late January, has forgiven Brielle.

Amara, in late January, is not, anymore, going to be close friends with Brielle.

Both are true. Both are mature. Both are what a twelve-year-old who has been in the cohort since first grade has, by Ms. Calloway's long careful design, learned how to do.

Forgiveness is not trust.

Carry that with you for the rest of your life.

— J.A.R.